CHAPTER 7

P A L E S T I N E A N D T H E A R A B W O R L D

THE ARAB POSITION

The Arab world insists, with a single voice, that the fundamental principle of long-term policy with respect to Palestine must be the establishment there of an independent Arab State. The Arabs profess no lack of sympathy with the plight of homeless Jews. But they deny that the solution for Jewish homelessness is a National Home in Palestine. Why, they ask, should Palestine be singled out? Why not settle homeless Jews in the United States, in England, Canada, or Australia? Why should the Arabs be asked to give up their claim to ultimate sovereignty over a land in which they are now -- and have been for centuries -- an overwhelming majority? What right have Western statesmen to promise another people a national home in an Arab land?

Three principal lines of argument are commonly advanced against the idea of converting Palestine into an Arab State. These are: (1) that there are several other Arab States, with a total area more than a hundred and sixty times as great as that of Palestine (and with potentially rich undeveloped land) while Jews have no State of their own; (2) that Jews have a special claim to Palestine based on historical connection, international pledges, and need; and (3) that Jewish development in Palestine is bringing great economic benefits to the Arabs. None of these has any force in Arab ears. Raising these lines of argument with a Syrian nationalist, we were asked in return, "Is the United States prepared to give up one of her 48 States to Italy or Poland if it be shown that they are overpopulated and need more land? Does not the United States have 47 other States, which still have great possibilities of development?" With all due consideration of the imperfections of the analogy, the Syrian was pointing to a fundamental truth.

No nation has ever stood in judgment against itself and said: "Here is a part of our national territory. We live in it.